NITROUS OXIDE

Also known as BALLOONS, laughing gas or NOS



Large, brightly labelled canisters like these are used to fill balloons.

What is it?

Nitrous oxide is a gas inhaled recreationally for a brief high. Its effects usually last a few minutes.

How is it taken?

Gas from large pressurised catering-style canisters is commonly released into balloons and inhaled.

How can it affect you?

It can cause euphoria, dizziness, confusion, slowed reactions, poor judgement and loss of balance.

Do not drive

Nitrous oxide can impair concentration, coordination and judgement. A brief high can still lead to a crash, putting passengers, pedestrians and other road users at risk.

Immediate dangers

It can cause fainting, loss of consciousness, oxygen deprivation, falls and serious injuries. Direct exposure to pressurised gas can cause cold burns.

Longer-term harm

Repeated or heavy use can stop vitamin B12 working properly, damaging nerves and the spinal cord. Some people develop long-lasting difficulty walking.

THE KEY MESSAGE

A short-lived high does not mean the risks are short-lived. Never drive after taking nitrous oxide.

RECOGNISE THE SIGNS. GET HELP EARLY.

Practical information for individuals, parents and families.

Warning signs that need medical attention

Pins and needles or numbness in the hands or feet; weakness; stumbling or difficulty walking; poor balance; memory or concentration problems; changes in bladder or bowel control.

WHAT TO DO

Stop using nitrous oxide. If there is numbness, weakness or difficulty walking, seek urgent medical assessment and tell the clinician about nitrous oxide use. Do not assume vitamin B12 tablets alone will prevent or treat nerve damage.

Call 999 if someone collapses, is unconscious, has a seizure or has serious breathing difficulties. Do not let anyone drive while affected.

UK LAW

Since 8 November 2023, nitrous oxide has been a Class C drug when intended for wrongful inhalation.

- POSSESSION for recreational inhalation: Up to 2 years in prison, an unlimited fine, or both.
- SELLING / SUPPLYING for wrongful inhalation: Up to 14 years in prison, an unlimited fine, or both.
- DRUG-DRIVING: Minimum 1-year ban, unlimited fine, up to 6 months in prison and a criminal record.

Penalties are maximums except the stated minimum ban. Legitimate uses remain lawful.

WHY THIS MATTERS TO SOUTH ASIAN COMMUNITIES

A UK study of 119 patients with nitrous oxide-related nerve and spinal cord injury found 68 (57%) were Asian or Asian British. These were selected hospital cases, not a national rate.

Stigma and fear of judgement can prevent people asking for help. A calm, private conversation can make a difference.

LOCAL SUPPORT IN ROCHDALE

TURNING POINT / ROAR

Adult drug and alcohol support | 0300 555 0234

EARLY BREAK

Young people and families | 0161 723 3880

Seeking help is a sign of strength, not shame.

Sources: Home Office (2023); GOV.UK drug penalties and drug-driving law; Mair et al. (2023).